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CUET UG

History

Harappan Civilisation & Archaeology

Theme 1 · Bricks, Beads and Bones · CUET UG 2027 Complete Mastery

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Syllabus Alignment & Chapter Architecture

Sub-Topic Domain	Official NTA CUET UG Unit I Syllabus Scope	High-Frequency Cognitive Skills Tested
Geographical & Subsistence	Mature Harappan chronology (2600–1900 BCE); geographical boundaries; agricultural tools, grains, and animal husbandry.	Associating sites with specific subsistence discoveries (ploughed field at Kalibangan, canal traces at Shortughai, rice at Lothal).
Planned Urban Architecture	Mohenjodaro layout: Citadel vs Lower Town; standardized brick ratio (1 : 2 : 4); street grid; Great Bath; drainage and domestic wells.	Differentiating public ritual structures from private residential architecture; analyzing sanitary drainage engineering.
Craft & Resource Networks	Chanhudaro craft production (beads, seals, shell); raw material procurement (Khetri copper, Shortughai lapis, Oman trade, Meluhha).	Tracing trade geography and raw material sources; interpreting Mesopotamian cuneiform terminology (Dilmun, Magan, Meluhha).
Social Organization & Authority	Burials and luxury goods (faience); undeciphered script (right-to-left); binary and decimal weights; theories of governance.	Analyzing socio-economic differentiation via grave goods; evaluating hypotheses of single ruler vs dispersed chiefdoms.
Archaeological Historiography	Discovery history: Alexander Cunningham's confusion, John Marshall's horizontal method, Mortimer Wheeler's stratigraphic revolution.	Chronological ordering of Director-Generals of ASI; evaluating stratigraphic methodology vs arbitrary horizontal trenching.

CUET HIGH-SCORING INSIGHT & KEY COGNITIVE TRAPS

History Theme 1 generates high-frequency factual and assertion-reason questions in CUET UG:

1. **Mesopotamian Terminology: Dilmun** = Bahrain; **Magan** = Oman; **Meluhha** = Harappan region (land of seafarers). The **Haja-bird** of Meluhha is identified as the **peacock**.
2. **Agricultural Sites:** Terracotta toy ploughs = **Banawali** (Haryana) and **Cholistan**; Ploughed field with two intersecting furrows = **Kalibangan** (Rajasthan); Water reservoirs = **Dholavira** (Gujarat); Canals = **Shortughai** (Afghanistan).
3. **Standardized Brick Ratio:** The dimensions of Mature Harappan burnt bricks followed an unvarying ratio: Length was 4 times thickness, and breadth was 2 times thickness (Thickness : Breadth : Length = 1 : 2 : 4).
4. **Stratigraphic Revolution: John Marshall** excavated horizontally across mounds ignoring stratigraphy, mixing artifacts of different epochs. **Mortimer Wheeler** (1944) introduced strict military precision by digging according to the **stratigraphy of the mound**.

Geographical Horizon & Subsistence Strategies

The Indus Valley or Harappan Civilisation represents South Asia's earliest urban epoch. Archaeologists designate the urban zenith as the **Mature Harappan culture** (dated between c. 2600 BCE and 1900 BCE), distinguishing it from preceding Early Harappan regional cultures and succeeding Late Harappan rural settlements.

Spatial Extent & Core Geographic Coordinates

The civilization spanned over a million square kilometers, encompassing modern Pakistan, northwest India, and northeastern Afghanistan:

- **Northernmost Limit:** Manda (Jammu & Kashmir) on the Chenab River.
- **Southernmost Limit:** Daimabad (Maharashtra) on the Pravara River.
- **Westernmost Limit:** Sutkagendor (Makran coast, Balochistan, Pakistan-Iran border).
- **Easternmost Limit:** Alamgirpur (Meerut district, Uttar Pradesh) on the Hindon River.

Subsistence Base & Agro-Pastoral Practices

Harappan urban centers were sustained by extensive agrarian hinterlands. Archaeo-botanists and archaeo-zoologists have reconstructed their dietary spectrum:

- **Cultivated Crops:** Wheat, barley, lentil, chickpea, sesame, and mustard. Millets have been excavated in large quantities from settlements in Gujarat (e.g., Lothal, Rangpur). Finding **rice grains** was exceptionally rare, with trace grains identified at Lothal and Rangpur.
- **Domesticated Fauna:** Bones of cattle, sheep, goat, buffalo, and pig indicate established pastoralism. Wild species (boar, deer, gharial) and fish remains confirm dietary diversification.

Agricultural Technologies and Irrigation Engineering

Agricultural cultivation in semi-arid zones relied on sophisticated technological adaptations:

- **Plough Agriculture:** Terracotta models of the plough have been discovered at **Banawali** (Haryana) and in **Cholistan** (the desert expanse of southern Pakistan bordering the Thar Desert).
- **Ploughed Agricultural Field:** Excavations at **Kalibangan** (Rajasthan) revealed an Early Harappan ploughed field displaying two perpendicular sets of furrows crossing at right angles, proving that two distinct crops were cultivated simultaneously.
- **Irrigation Infrastructure:** Traces of irrigation canals have been identified at the frontier outpost of **Shortughai** (Northern Afghanistan). Intriguingly, no definite canal networks survived in the alluvial heartlands of Sindh or Punjab, where annual Indus inundations or deep wells sufficed.
- **Hydraulic Water Reservoirs:** At **Dholavira** (Khadir Bet, Rann of Kutch, Gujarat), massive stone-cut rainwater harvesting reservoirs were constructed to collect and channel surface run-off for agriculture and urban consumption.
- **Grain Processing Hardware:** Saddles querns (**grinding stones**) carved from hard volcanic or sandstone rocks were ubiquitous, categorized into querns for grinding grains and querns for pounding aromatic herbs and spices.

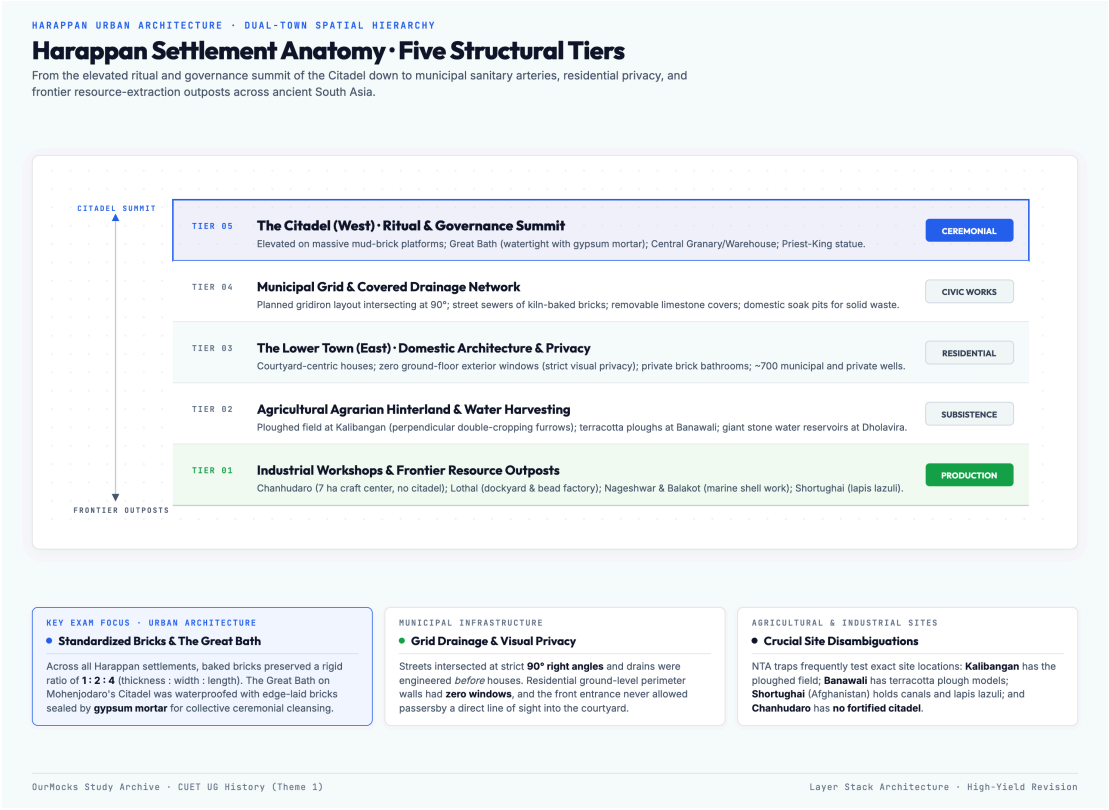


Figure 1: Urban Planning Architecture: Mohenjodaro Citadel, Drainage Grids, and Civic Engineering

Urbanism & Civic Planning: The Archetype of Mohenjodaro

The hallmark of the Harappan civilization is its planned urban layout. Mohenjodaro (literally "Mound of the Dead"), situated on the right bank of the Indus River in Sindh, provides the most complete urban blueprint.

Dual Settlement Topology: Citadel and Lower Town

The urban settlements were typically partitioned into two distinct physical sectors:

Planning Parameter	The Citadel (Upper Town)	The Lower Town (Residential)
Topographic Elevation	Elevated on massive artificial mud-brick platforms (up to 12m high).	Built at natural ground level or lower platforms.
Spatial Dimensions	Smaller in geographical area; highly fortified and defended.	Substantially larger in geographical area; housed residential quarters.
Enclosure Architecture	Surrounded by defensive perimeter walls physically separated from Lower Town.	Also enclosed by defensive boundary walls with regulated entry gates.
Institutional Function	Dedicated to public administration, civic assemblies, and state rituals.	Accommodated residential domestic life, workshops, and retail bazaars.

Standardized Mud-Brick Architecture

Every Harappan brick—whether sun-dried or kiln-fired—adhered strictly to a standardized mathematical proportion across all urban settlements:

$$\text{Thickness} : \text{Width} : \text{Length} = 1 : 2 : 4$$

Standard bricks measured 7 cm × 14 cm × 28 cm (for domestic walls) or 10 cm × 20 cm × 40 cm (for massive civic platform retaining walls).

The Orthogonal Street Grid & Municipal Drainage System

One of the most remarkable features of Harappan engineering was its planned drainage network:

- **Gridiron Pattern:** Major thoroughfares and arterial lanes were laid out along an orthogonal **grid pattern**, intersecting at clean right angles.
- **Sequential Construction Logic:** Drains and streets were laid out first; domestic residential houses were subsequently constructed abutting the streets.
- **Drainage Integration:** Every household had at least one exterior wall bordering a public street. Domestic wastewater flowed through private wall channels into covered street drains.
- **Sanitary Maintenance:** Street drains were constructed of burnt brick set in gypsum mortar and covered with loose, removable brick slabs or limestone blocks, permitting municipal cleaning crews to lift covers and clear silt accumulation.

Domestic Architecture: Privacy and Courtyards

Residential architecture in the Lower Town reflected distinct socio-cultural priorities:

- **Courtyard-Centred Design:** Domestic houses were structured around a central open-air courtyard, which functioned as the hub of household activities (cooking, spinning, weaving).
- **Obsession with Privacy:** Zero exterior windows existed in ground-floor walls. Furthermore, the main entrance hallway was strategically positioned so that it did not afford visitors a direct line of sight into the central courtyard.
- **Private Sanitation:** Every home featured a private paved bathroom connected via wall drains to the street network. Multi-story dwellings featured brick-built staircases.
- **Abundance of Wells:** Circular brick-lined wells were often located in exterior rooms accessible directly from the street for passing travelers. Mohenjodaro alone accommodated approximately **700 domestic wells**.

Monumental Civic Architecture on the Citadel

1. The Great Bath

The most famous public structure on the Mohenjodaro Citadel is the Great Bath:

- **Dimensions & Architecture:** A rectangular tank situated in an open courtyard surrounded by a colonnaded corridor on all four sides.
- **Access Steps:** Two flights of brick steps descend into the pool from the north and south.
- **Hydraulic Waterproofing:** The tank was rendered completely watertight through three layers: bricks set on edge, mortar of gypsum, and a backing layer of natural bitumen (**asphalt**).
- **Water Supply & Drainage:** Water was fed from an adjacent room containing a massive well, and emptied after use through a large corbelled brick drain.
- **Ritual Function:** Eight individual bathrooms flanked an adjoining lane. Scholars universally agree the Great Bath was constructed for special religious or purification rituals.

2. The Granary / Warehouse

A colossal brick foundation platform measuring 45 m × 15 m, featuring 27 brick blocks separated by narrow ventilation passages to prevent dampness and grain spoilage. The upper structure, made of perishable timber, decayed in antiquity.

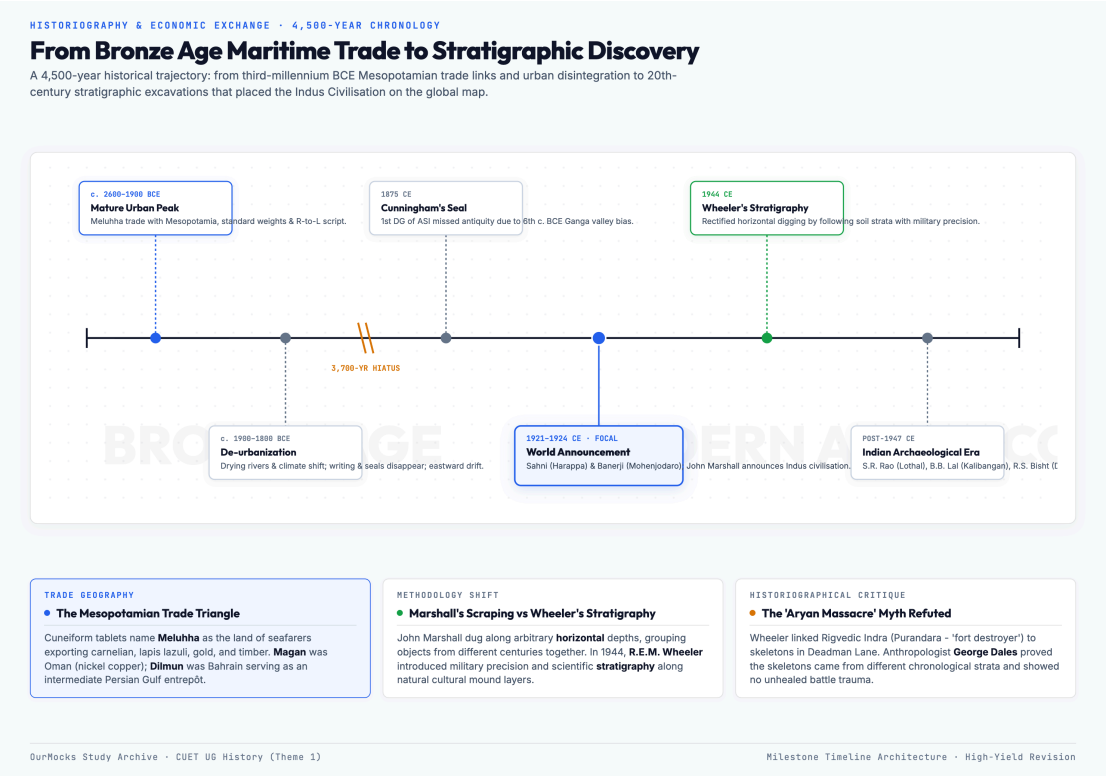


Figure 2: Craft Specialization, Metallurgy, Trade Routes, and Mineral Procurement Networks

Specialized Craft Production and Procurement Networks

Craft manufacturing was the commercial backbone of Harappan prosperity, exhibiting advanced metallurgical, ceramic, and lapidary skill.

Chanhudaro: The Dedicated Craft Hub

Situated approximately 130 km south of Mohenjodaro, Chanhudaro was a tiny settlement (less than 7 hectares) dedicated almost exclusively to craft manufacturing:

- **Craft Specializations:** Bead-making, shell-cutting, metal-working, seal-engraving, and weight-manufacturing.
- **Lapidary Raw Materials:** Carnelian (a beautiful fiery red stone), jasper, crystal, quartz, steatite, copper, bronze, gold, shell, faience, and terracotta.
- **Technological Innovation: Carnelian** beads were manufactured by firing yellowish nodules at various production stages to produce their rich red color. **Steatite** (a very soft soapstone) was ground into a powder, mixed with water into a paste, and molded into micro-beads of extraordinary precision.
- **Specialized Drills:** Specialized copper and stone fluted drills have been excavated at Chanhudaro, Lothal, and Dholavira.

Coastal Shell-Working Centers: Nageshwar and Balakot

Situated on the maritime coasts of Gujarat and Pakistan, Nageshwar and Balakot specialized in the manufacture of shell objects—bangles, ladles, inlays, and spoons—which were transported inland to major urban centers.

Domestic Raw Material Procurement Networks

The Harappans established specialized outposts and sent expeditions to secure raw materials unavailable in the alluvial Indus floodplains:

- **Copper:** Procured from the **Khetri mines of Rajasthan** through contact with the local indigenous **Ganeshwar-Jodhpura culture**.
- **Gold:** Procured from the Kolar goldfields of South India.
- **Steatite:** Sourced from southern Rajasthan and northern Gujarat.
- **Lapis Lazuli:** A deep blue metamorphic stone of supreme prestige, secured by establishing a dedicated trading colony at **Shortughai** in Badakhshan, northern Afghanistan.
- **Carnelian:** Sourced from Bharuch and Ratanpur in Gujarat (channeled via the port of Lothal).

International Long-Distance Maritime Commerce

Harappan trade extended across the Persian Gulf to ancient Western Asia:

- **Omani Copper:** Cuneiform records and chemical spectrometry reveal that copper found in Mesopotamia and Harappan sites contains distinctive traces of **nickel**, proving a shared origin from the Sultanate of Oman (Magan).
- **Mesopotamian Cuneiform Geography (3rd Millennium BCE):**
  - **Dilmun:** The island of Bahrain in the Persian Gulf (an entrepôt of pearl and copper trade).
  - **Magan:** The coastal peninsula of Oman.
  - **Meluhha:** The land of seafarers, identified conclusively as the Harappan region.
- **Trade Goods from Meluhha:** Cuneiform inscriptions record the import of carnelian, lapis lazuli, copper, gold, ivory, and exotic woods from Meluhha.
- **The Haja-Bird:** Cuneiform texts proclaim: **"May your bird be the haja-bird, may its call be heard in the royal palace."** Archaeologists identify the sacred haja-bird as the **peacock**.

Social Stratification, Script, and Administrative Authority

Archaeologists deploy two primary methodologies to discern social differentiation within ancient societies:

1. Mortuary Analysis (Burials)

- **Burial Practices:** Harappan deceased were placed in rectangular burial pits lined with brick, oriented north-south.
- **Grave Goods:** Pits contained utilitarian earthenware pottery, copper mirrors, bone ornaments, and shell beads. A burial excavated at Harappa in the 1980s revealed a male skull accompanied by an ornament of 3 shell rings, a jasper bead, and hundreds of micro-beads.
- **Egalitarian Burial Philosophy:** Unlike ancient Egyptian pharaohs or Mesopotamian royal tombs, Harappans generally did **not** bury immense hoards of gold, precious jewels, or weapons with the dead.

2. Identifying Luxuries vs. Utilitarian Artifacts

- **Utilitarian Objects:** Objects of daily practical use manufactured from ubiquitous, local materials (clay, stone), including saddle querns, clay bowls, bone needles, and terracotta flesh-rubbers.
- **Luxury Artifacts:** Costly objects made of rare, non-local materials requiring complex pyrotechnological processing. Prime examples include miniature vessels made of **faience** (ground sand/silica mixed with gum and fired to create a glossy glassy surface), used as luxury cosmetic perfume containers, and hoards of micro-gold jewelry found at Harappa and Mohenjodaro.

The Enigmatic Script

The Harappan script remains undeciphered, guarding its linguistic secrets:

- **Logographic / Pictographic Character:** The script contains between **375 and 400 distinct signs**. It is clearly logo-syllabic rather than alphabetic.
- **Direction of Writing:** Written from **right to left**. Archaeologists deduce this from seals where signs are comfortably spaced on the right side but cramped on the left, proving the engraver began writing from the right.
- **Inscriptional Media:** Signs appear on steatite seals, copper tablets, bronze tools, carnelian beads, bone rods, terracotta jars, and a monumental wooden signboard excavated at Dholavira containing ten massive 37 cm tall signs.

Precision Weight Systems

Commerce was regulated through an exquisite, standardized weight system:

- **Material:** Weights were carved from **chert** stone into perfect cubes with zero face markings.
- **Dual Numerical Grading:**
  - Lower denominations were **binary**: $1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, \ldots$ up to $12,800$. The unit weight 16 equaled approximately 13.71 grams.
  - Higher denominations followed the **decimal system** in multiples of 160, 200, 320, and 640.

Theories of Ancient Authority & Governance

The remarkable uniformity across Harappan seals, weights, pottery, and standardized brick ratios implies centralized political authority. Archaeologists propose three competing paradigms:

1. **Single Unified Imperial State:** Supported by evidence of uniform settlement planning, coordinated brick ratios, and strategic resource outposts.
2. **Multiple City-States / Decentralized Chiefdoms:** Suggesting separate kings or ruling oligarchies for Mohenjodaro, Harappa, and Lothal.
3. **Egalitarian Polity with No Single Ruler:** A collective civic body where all community members shared power.

- **The "Priest-King" Sculpture:** A famous steatite stone bust excavated at Mohenjodaro depicting a bearded male figure dressed in an embroidered trefoil-patterned shawl draped over his left shoulder, christened the "Priest-King" by John Marshall in analogy to Mesopotamian priest-rulers.

The Decline of the Civilisation & Archaeological Historiography

By 1800 BCE, most Mature Harappan urban centers were abandoned, followed by a transformation into impoverished, rural **Late Harappan** or post-urban regional cultures.

Hypotheses for Civilizational Collapse

Archaeologists attribute the urban collapse to a confluence of ecological and systemic failures:

- **Climatic Desiccation & Deforestation:** Massive fuel consumption for firing millions of bricks and smelting copper exhausted forests, triggering rainfall declines.
- **Hydrological Shifting & Flooding:** Shifting of the course of the Indus River inundated cities, while the drying up of the Hakra-Ghaggar river system caused agricultural devastation in Rajasthan.
- **Overuse of the Landscape:** Over-grazing and agricultural salinization depleted soil fertility.

- **The Refuted "Aryan Invasion" Hypothesis:** In the 1940s, Sir Mortimer Wheeler argued that nomadic Aryan invaders described in the Rigveda destroyed the Harappan cities, citing thirty-seven unburied human skeletons found in a lane at Mohenjodaro. Subsequent forensic and stratigraphic analysis by George Dales demonstrated these deaths occurred across different periods with zero evidence of military conquest.

Historiography: Pioneers of Indus Archaeology

Archaeologist	Institutional Role	Historical Contribution & Methodological Impact
Alexander Cunningham	First Director-General of ASI (1871)	Focused on the historic period (6th c. BCE to 4th c. CE) using Chinese Buddhist pilgrim texts. Confused by a Harappan seal because he could not fit it into his historical framework.
Daya Ram Sahni & R.D. Banerji	ASI Excavators (1921–1922)	Excavated the ancient mounds at Harappa (Sahni, 1921) and Mohenjodaro (Banerji, 1922), discovering identical steatite seals and brick architecture.
Sir John Marshall	Director-General of ASI (1902–1928)	Announced the discovery of the Indus Civilisation to the world in 1924. Methodological limitation: excavated horizontally across uniform levels, ignoring stratigraphy.
R.E.M. (Mortimer) Wheeler	Director-General of ASI (1944–1948)	Revolutionized Indian archaeology by introducing the military precision of **stratigraphic excavation**—recording precise geological layer depth rather than horizontal planes.

Religious Practices and Archaeological Interpretations

Reconstructing religious beliefs from mute material remains is one of the most perilous frontiers in archaeology. Archaeologists rely heavily on analogies with later Hinduism:

1. The "Mother Goddess" Cult

Excavators at Mohenjodaro unearthed numerous terracotta figurines depicting heavily ornamented female figures:

- **Iconography:** Elaborate head-dresses, heavy necklaces, and waist-cloths, often bearing traces of smoke stains, suggesting their usage as incense burners in domestic shrines.
- **Interpretive Analogy:** Drawing parallels with later fertility cults, scholars classified these terracotta figures as **Mother Goddesses** symbolizing agrarian fertility and generation.

2. The "Proto-Shiva" Pashupati Seal

The famous steatite seal excavated at Mohenjodaro depicts a seated male figure that John Marshall identified as a precursor to the Hindu deity Shiva:

- **Yogic Posture:** The figure is depicted seated cross-legged on a low stool in a **yogic asana**, wearing a horned headdress.

- **Surrounding Faunal Assemblage:** The central figure is surrounded by four wild beasts—an **elephant**, a **tiger**, a **rhinoceros**, and a **water buffalo**—while two deer are depicted prancing beneath the seat.
- **Historiographical Debates:** While Marshall christened the figure "Proto-Shiva" or **Pashupati** ("Lord of Beasts"), later historians noted that the Rigvedic deity **Rudra** is depicted as a fierce archer rather than a yogic lord of beasts, suggesting caution against hasty retrospective projections.

3. Tree, Plant, and Animal Veneration

- **Sacred Flora:** Numerous seals depict the sacred **Pipal tree** (Ficus religiosa) revered in religious rituals, showing deep continuities with later Indian spiritual traditions.
- **Mythical Fauna:** The single most common motif on Harappan seals is the **unicorn**—a mythical, one-horned bovine creature whose biological identity remains enigmatic.

4. Conical Stone Objects: Lingas or Gaming Pieces?

Excavations yielded numerous small, highly polished conical stone objects carved from chalcedony and agate:

- **Marshall's Theory:** Interpreted them as **lingas** (phallic emblems representing Shiva).
- **Modern Skepticism:** Contemporary archaeologists suggest many of these smooth conical objects served mundane utilitarian roles as **gaming pieces** for board games or precision measuring standards.

Chronological Timeline of Major Indus Archaeological Milestones

Year	Pioneering Archaeologist	Landmark Breakthrough or Excavation Milestone
1875	Alexander Cunningham	Publishes the very first academic report on an inscribed Harappan steatite seal.
1921	Daya Ram Sahni	Discovers seals and commences systematic excavations at Harappa in Punjab.
1922	Rakhaldas (R.D.) Banerji	Unearths matching steatite seals and brick mounds at Mohenjodaro in Sindh.
1924	Sir John Marshall	Formally announces the discovery of the ancient Indus Civilisation to the world.
1944	Sir Mortimer Wheeler	Assumes Director-Generalship of ASI; introduces military stratigraphic digging.
1955	S.R. Rao	Commences excavations at Lothal, unearthing the tidal dockyard and bead factory.
1960	B.B. Lal & B.K. Thapar	Begin intensive excavations at Kalibangan, uncovering the criss-cross ploughed field.
1974	M.R. Mughal	Initiates extensive archaeological explorations across the dried Hakra river in Cholistan.
1990	R.S. Bisht	Commences excavations at Dholavira, revealing giant water reservoirs and stadium.

Cultural Continuity & The Living Legacy of Harappan Material Traditions

Far from being an isolated, extinguished Bronze Age anomaly, Harappan urbanism transmitted vital technological, cognitive, and cultural practices into historical and contemporary South Asian civilization:

1. Numismatic and Metrological Continuities

The binary weight standard established by Harappan chert weights endured across three millennia of Indian commercial history:

- **The Ratio of Sixteen:** The Harappan base unit 16 (approximately 13.7 grams) survived in traditional Indian metrology, where 1 Rupee was officially subdivided into 16 Annas until the decimal currency reform of 1957.
- **Standardized Brick Dimensions:** The rectangular proportional brick format (1 : 2 : 4) laid out in Mature Harappan kilns continued to serve as the structural standard in classical Indian civic and temple construction.

2. Socio-Religious and Cultural Continuities

- **Sacred Water Tanks and Ritual Ablutions:** The Great Bath of Mohenjodaro represents the conceptual ancestor of the temple stepwells (**baolis**) and sacred bathing tanks (**kunds**) ubiquitous across Hindu, Jain, and Buddhist sacred architecture.
- **Iconographic Traditions:** Veneration of the sacred Pipal tree (**Ashvattha**), terracotta female fertility amulets, phallic stone emblems, and the **swastika** symbol all trace their earliest excavated antecedents to Harappan stratigraphy.
- **Everyday Technologies:** Terracotta toy carts excavated at Harappa and Chanhudaro display identical solid wheel geometry and axle mechanics to the traditional wooden bullock carts still utilized in rural Sindh and Haryana today.

3. Modern Scientific Frontiers in Harappan Archaeology

In the 21st century, archaeology has transcended pickaxes to incorporate cutting-edge forensic sciences:

- **Palaeo-Environmental Satellite Mapping:** ISRO and NASA satellite radar imagery successfully traced the dried-up subterranean palaeo-channels of the legendary Vedic Saraswati (Ghaggar-Hakra system).
- **Ancient DNA (aDNA) Analysis at Rakhigarhi:** Genetic sequencing of skeletal remains from the Rakhigarhi cemetery demonstrated genetic continuity with modern South Asian populations, confirming that the founders of Harappan civilization were indigenous to the subcontinent.

Chapter Synthesis & Cognitive Mindmap



Figure 3: Hierarchical Knowledge Architecture: Harappan Urbanism, Economy, Material Culture, and Historiography

CUET HIGH-YIELD MEMORY HOOKS & EPISTEMIC ASSOCIATIONS

- **Chronology:** Mature Harappan = 2600–1900 BCE; Early Harappan = pre-urban regional; Late Harappan = post-urban rural.
- **Key Archaeological Sites & Discoveries:**
  - **Harappa:** First discovered site (Sahni, 1921); Granaries; jewelled skull burial.
  - **Mohenjodaro:** Great Bath; Granary; Bronze Dancing Girl; Priest-King; 700 domestic wells.
  - **Chanhudaro:** Exclusively devoted to craft (bead-making, micro-steatite beads); no Citadel.
  - **Kalibangan:** Ploughed field with intersecting furrows; fire altars; black bangles.
  - **Lothal:** Tidal dockyard; Bhogavo river; carnelian bead factory; rice husks; fire altars.
  - **Dholavira:** Tripartite town planning; 10-sign signboard; giant stone-cut water reservoirs.
  - **Banawali:** Terracotta toy ploughs; radial street pattern.
  - **Shortughai:** Northern Afghanistan outpost; lapis lazuli; canal traces.
  - **Nageshwar & Balakot:** Coastal shell production (bangles, ladles, inlays).
- **Brick Ratio:** Strictly 1 : 2 : 4 (Thickness : Width : Length) across all Mature Harappan settlements.
- **Script & Weights:** Undeciphered, logo-syllabic (375–400 signs), written right-to-left; weights carved from chert, lower binary $(1, 2, 4, 8, 16, ...)$, upper decimal.
- **ASI Historiography:** Cunningham (confused by timeline) → Marshall (1924 announcement, horizontal digging) → Wheeler (1944, stratigraphic revolution).

MASTER STRATEGY CHEATSHEET — HARAPPAN ARCHAEOLOGY

1. Geographical Boundaries:

- North: Manda (J&K); South: Daimabad (Maharashtra); West: Sutkagendor (Balochistan); East: Alamgirpur (UP).

2. Agriculture & Subsistence:

- Ploughed field: Kalibangan; Toy ploughs: Banawali & Cholistan; Canals: Shortughai; Reservoirs: Dholavira; Rice: Lothal.

3. Mohenjodaro Architecture:

- Citadel (upper, platforms, walled, Great Bath) vs Lower Town (residential, grid street, private wells, covered drains).
- Standard brick ratio: 1 : 2 : 4. Great bath sealed with gypsum mortar and natural bitumen.

4. Craft & Trade Networks:

- Chanhudaro (bead-making, steatite); Nageshwar/Balakot (shell); Shortughai (lapis lazuli); Khetri (copper); Kolar (gold).
- Mesopotamia trade: Dilmun (Bahrain), Magan (Oman), Meluhha (Harappa). Meluhha's sacred bird: Haja-bird (peacock).

5. Weights & Script:

- Script: 375-400 signs, right-to-left, undeciphered. Weights: Chert, binary (1 to 12,800) and decimal.

6. ASI Pioneers:

- Cunningham (1st DG, 1871); John Marshall (1924 discovery announcement); Mortimer Wheeler (1944, stratigraphy).

THE SEVEN FATAL CUET TRAPS — HARAPPAN CIVILISATION

- **Trap 1: Canal Irrigation in Punjab/Sindh:** Traces of canals were found **only** at Shortughai in Afghanistan, NOT in Punjab or Sindh!
- **Trap 2: Rice vs Other Grains:** Wheat and barley were main staples; finding **rice** was rare (found only at Lothal and Rangpur).
- **Trap 3: Direction of Script:** Harappan script was written from **Right to Left**, NOT left to right! (Evidenced by cramping on the left).
- **Trap 4: Burial Goods Philosophy:** Harappans did **not** bury immense hoards of precious gold or jewelry with the dead, unlike Egyptian pharaohs.
- **Trap 5: Marshall vs Wheeler Methodology:** Marshall excavated **horizontally**, ignoring stratigraphy. Wheeler revolutionized archaeology by following the **stratigraphy of the mound**.
- **Trap 6: Aryan Invasion Myth:** The "massacre at Mohenjodaro" cited by Wheeler was thoroughly refuted by modern archaeologists (George Dales).
- **Trap 7: Chanhudaro Fortification:** Unlike Mohenjodaro and Harappa, Chanhudaro had **no fortified Citadel** and was devoted entirely to craft production.

Exam-Style Practice Questions & Detailed Solutions

Part 1: High-Yield Conceptual Foundations & Subsistence (Q1 to Q5)

Q1. At which of the following Harappan archaeological sites did excavators discover an Early Harappan agricultural field containing two perpendicular sets of ploughed furrows intersecting at right angles, demonstrating the simultaneous cultivation of two distinct crops?

(A) Banawali in Haryana
(B) Kalibangan in Rajasthan
(C) Lothal in Gujarat
(D) Shortughai in Afghanistan

Sol. Q1. Ploughed Field Discovery:

- Excavations at **Kalibangan** (Rajasthan) on the banks of the Ghaggar-Hakra river brought to light an agricultural field with criss-cross furrows.
- The two sets of furrows crossing at right angles prove that two crops (such as mustard and gram) were grown together.

Therefore, the site is **Kalibangan in Rajasthan** (Option B). **Answer: (B)**

Q2. In ancient Mesopotamian cuneiform texts of the third millennium BCE, the Harappan region is frequently referred to as the 'land of seafarers' using which geographical toponym?

(A) Meluhha
(B) Dilmun
(C) Magan
(D) Ur

Sol. Q2. Mesopotamian Toponyms:

- Cuneiform inscriptions refer to **Meluhha** as the land of seafarers, exporting carnelian, lapis lazuli, copper, and gold.
- **Dilmun** refers to Bahrain, and **Magan** refers to the Sultanate of Oman.

Therefore, the Harappan region was called **Meluhha** (Option A). **Answer: (A)**

Q3. What was the standardized mathematical ratio of dimensions (Thickness : Width : Length) adhered to by burnt and sun-dried bricks across all Mature Harappan urban settlements?

(A) 1 : 3 : 6
(B) 1 : 2 : 3
(C) 1 : 2 : 4
(D) 1 : 4 : 8

Sol. Q3. Standardized Brick Ratio:

- Across all Mature Harappan sites from Mohenjodaro to Lothal, bricks followed an identical dimensional ratio where the width was twice the thickness, and length was four times the thickness (1 : 2 : 4).

Therefore, the correct ratio is 1 : 2 : 4 (Option C). **Answer: (C)**

Q4. At which frontier outpost in Northern Afghanistan did archaeologists discover definitive physical evidence of canal irrigation networks constructed during the Harappan Civilisation?

(A) Sutkagendor
(B) Shortughai
(C) Kot Diji
(D) Daimabad

Sol. Q4. Canal Irrigation at Shortughai:

- Physical traces of Harappan canals have been excavated at **Shortughai** in Badakhshan, northern Afghanistan, situated near lapis lazuli mines.
- No definite traces of canals survived in the alluvial plains of Sindh or Punjab.

Therefore, the site is **Shortughai** (Option B). **Answer: (B)**

Q5. Which of the following small Harappan settlements (measuring less than 7 hectares) was devoted almost exclusively to specialized craft production, including bead-making, shell-cutting, seal-engraving, and weight-manufacturing?

(A) Kalibangan
(B) Harappa
(C) Chanhudaro
(D) Dholavira

Sol. Q5. Chanhudaro Craft Center:

- **Chanhudaro** was a tiny industrial settlement situated south of Mohenjodaro, almost completely devoted to specialized craft activities.
- Unlike major administrative cities, Chanhudaro had no fortified Citadel.

Therefore, the settlement is **Chanhudaro** (Option C). **Answer: (C)**

Part 2: Applied Urban Planning & Material Culture (Q6 to Q10)

Q6. Which method was deployed by the builders of Mohenjodaro to make the Great Bath completely watertight and prevent water seepage through the brick floor and walls?

(A) Applying thick layers of kiln-fired glazed porcelain tiles
(B) Setting bricks on edge and using a mortar of gypsum backed by natural bitumen (asphalt)
(C) Lining the pool walls with solid sheets of melted copper and bronze
(D) Carving the entire basin out of a single monolithic granite outcrop

Sol. Q6. Waterproofing of the Great Bath:

- The Great Bath in the Mohenjodaro Citadel was made watertight by setting burnt bricks on edge, joining them with a **mortar of gypsum**, and laying a thick layer of **natural bitumen (asphalt)** along the sides.

Therefore, Option B accurately describes the engineering method. **Answer: (B)**

Q7. A unique Harappan coastal site in Gujarat features a massive stone-walled urban layout partitioned into three distinct sectors (Citadel, Middle Town, and Lower Town) along with giant stone-cut water reservoirs and a large ten-sign inscription. This site is:

(A) Lothal
(B) Rangpur
(C) Nageshwar
(D) Dholavira

Sol. Q7. Tripartite Layout of Dholavira:

- **Dholavira** in the Rann of Kutch (Gujarat) exhibits a unique tripartite division (Citadel, Middle Town, Lower Town), monumental stone architecture, giant water reservoirs, and a public signboard containing ten large Indus script signs.
- (Lothal is famous for its tidal dockyard, but lacks tripartite planning).

Therefore, the site is **Dholavira** (Option D). **Answer: (D)**

Q8. The Harappan cubical measuring weights were carved from which fine-grained mineral, and what numerical system did their lower denominations adhere to?

(A) Carved from chert; adhering to a binary numerical sequence $(1, 2, 4, 8, 16, ...)$
(B) Carved from steatite; adhering to an unstandardized octal system
(C) Carved from lapis lazuli; adhering to a purely decimal metric scale
(D) Carved from copper; adhering to a vigesimal base-twenty scale

Sol. Q8. Harappan Weight System:

- Harappan weights were typically carved from **chert** stone into perfect cubes with no markings.
- Lower denominations followed a **binary system** $(1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, ...$ up to 12,800), while higher weights followed the decimal system.

Therefore, Option A is correct. **Answer: (A)**

Q9. Match the Harappan raw material in Column I with its primary archaeological procurement source in Column II:

Column I (Material)	Column II (Procurement Source)
A. Lapis Lazuli	1. Khetri region of Rajasthan
B. Copper	2. Coastal Gujarat (Nageshwar/Balakot)
C. Gold	3. Shortughai in Northern Afghanistan
D. Shell	4. Kolar region of South India

Choose the correct matching code:

(A) A-1, B-3, C-4, D-2
(B) A-3, B-4, C-1, D-2
(C) A-3, B-1, C-4, D-2
(D) A-4, B-1, C-3, D-2

Sol. Q9. Raw Material Sourcing Matching:

- Lapis Lazuli: Shortughai in Northern Afghanistan (A-3).
- Copper: Khetri mines of Rajasthan (Ganeshwar-Jodhpura culture) (B-1).
- Gold: Kolar goldfields of South India (C-4).
- Shell: Coastal settlements of Nageshwar and Balakot (D-2).

Therefore, the correct matching code is A-3, B-1, C-4, D-2 (Option C). **Answer: (C)**

Q10. Why did the first Director-General of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), Alexander Cunningham, fail to recognize the profound antiquity of the Harappan seal given to him in the mid-nineteenth century?

(A) He believed that Indian urban history commenced only with the Gangetic cities of the sixth century BCE
(B) He mistakenly identified the seal as an imported Roman coin from Alexandria
(C) He concluded that the seal was a modern forgery created by British railway contractors
(D) He lacked access to radiocarbon dating laboratories in Calcutta

Sol. Q10. Cunningham's Historiographical Confusion:

- Alexander Cunningham's historical framework was rooted in Buddhist texts and Chinese pilgrim itineraries (c. 6th century BCE to 4th century CE).
- Because he believed Indian urbanization began in the Gangetic valley around the 6th century BCE, he could not fit the Bronze Age Harappan seal into his chronological framework.

Therefore, Option A explains Cunningham's dilemma. **Answer: (A)**

Part 3: Advanced Evaluative & Historiographical Vignettes (Q11 to Q15)

Q11. What critical methodological breakthrough did Sir R.E.M. (Mortimer) Wheeler introduce to Indian archaeology upon assuming the Director-Generalship of the ASI in 1944?

(A) He initiated the widespread deployment of satellite remote sensing across the Thar desert
(B) He pioneered underwater marine archaeology at Lothal dockyard
(C) He replaced arbitrary horizontal trenching with strict excavation according to the stratigraphy of the mound
(D) He deciphered the logo-syllabic Harappan script using bilingual Sumerian tablets

Sol. Q11. Wheeler's Stratigraphic Revolution:

- Mortimer Wheeler recognized that his predecessor, John Marshall, had excavated horizontally along uniform mechanical depths, thereby grouping artifacts from different geological strata into the same epoch.
- Wheeler introduced **stratigraphic excavation**, meticulously recording artifacts according to the physical stratigraphic layers of the mound.

Therefore, Option C accurately describes Wheeler's breakthrough. **Answer: (C)**

Q12. Consider the following two statements regarding Harappan Society and Archaeology: Statement I: Harappans engaged in lavish mortuary rituals, burying vast treasures of gold and precious gemstones with the dead to ensure status in the afterlife. Statement II: The Harappan script was written from right to left, as evidenced by wider spacing of characters on the right side and cramping on the left. Choose the correct option:

(A) Statement I is true, Statement II is false
(B) Statement I is false, Statement II is true
(C) Both Statement I and Statement II are true
(D) Both Statement I and Statement II are false

Sol. Q12. Evaluating Harappan Statements:

- Statement I is false: Harappan burials were modest, containing utilitarian pottery, copper mirrors, and beads. Unlike Egyptian pharaohs, Harappans did not bury immense wealth with the deceased.
- Statement II is true: Cramping of signs on the left edge of seals proves that engravers started writing from right to left.

Therefore, **Statement I is false, Statement II is true** (Option B). **Answer: (B)**

Q13. Archaeologists classify small vessels made of a manufactured material called 'faience' as luxury items in Harappan settlements primarily because:

(A) Faience was imported exclusively from dynastic Egypt at exorbitant freight costs
(B) Faience was crafted from rare silver ores found only in southern India
(C) Faience was an organic polymer that degraded rapidly unless preserved in airtight tombs
(D) Faience required a complex and difficult pyrotechnological process of grinding silica, mixing with gum, and firing to produce a glassy glaze

Sol. Q13. Luxury Nature of Faience:

- NCERT explains that objects made of **faience** (ground sand or silica mixed with color and gum and subsequently fired) were regarded as precious luxuries because they were difficult and costly to manufacture.
- Miniature faience pots were used as luxury cosmetic perfume vials.

Therefore, Option D correctly explains why faience was a luxury. **Answer: (D)**

Q14. Which of the following physical artifacts discovered at Mohenjodaro was labelled as a 'Priest-King' by early twentieth-century archaeologists by drawing a direct analogy with contemporary Mesopotamian political history?

(A) A steatite stone bust of a bearded male figure draped in an embroidered trefoil-patterned shawl
(B) A terracotta figurine of an armed warrior standing atop a two-wheeled chariot
(C) A bronze statuette of a young woman posed with one arm on her hip
(D) A polished sandstone torso with holes for attaching movable arms and head

Sol. Q14. The Priest-King Sculpture:

- The steatite stone sculpture of a bearded male figure wearing an embroidered shawl with trefoil motifs over his left shoulder was termed the **Priest-King** because archaeologists were familiar with Mesopotamian priest-kings.

Therefore, the sculpture is described in Option A. **Answer: (A)**

Q15. In an ancient Mesopotamian myth recorded in cuneiform tablets, the sacred bird of the distant land of Meluhha is referred to as the 'haja-bird'. Modern historians and ornithologists identify this legendary creature as the:

(A) Great Indian Bustard
(B) Himalayan Golden Eagle
(C) Indian River Tern
(D) Peacock (Mayura)

Sol. Q15. Identity of the Haja-Bird:

- The cuneiform text proclaims: **"May your bird be the haja-bird, may its call be heard in the royal palace."**
- Archaeologists and historians identify the haja-bird as the **peacock**, inspired by its distinctive vocal call and origin in the Indian subcontinent.

Therefore, the haja-bird is the **Peacock** (Option D). **Answer: (D)**